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Ingroup ambivalence and experienced affect: the moderating role of social identification

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Abstract

No previous work in the field of group-related attitudes and emotions has investigated the possible affective consequences of ingroup ambivalence—that is, the consequences of having attitudes towards an ingroup that are simultaneously both positive and negative. The current study was designed to explore this issue. Ambivalent attitudes have been argued to be more psychologically salient to the individual than univalent ones. A linear increase in participants' experienced affect was therefore predicted as a function of their ambivalence toward the ingroup. However, consistent with the predictions of social identity theory, previous findings have shown that higher ingroup identifiers are more likely to be involved with the ingroup than lower identifiers. Accordingly, we predicted and found effects of ingroup ambivalence on affect for high but not low ingroup identifiers. Combining the findings of two distinct literatures, the initial evidence provided by this study exploratively traces the sources of the affective processes that are set in motion by the evaluation of one's own group in an intergroup context. Copyright © 2003 John Wiley & Sons, Ltd.

Attitudinal ambivalence (Scott, 1966, 1969) has been defined as a co-existence of both positive and negative evaluations of a given attitude object (Jonas, Broemer, & Diehl, 2000; see also Conner & Sparks, 2002; Thompson, Zanna, & Griffin, 1995). At present, research on this construct concurs with that in other psychological domains proposing that a two-dimensional conceptualization of phenomena may actually be more adequate than a one-dimensional one (e.g. Cacioppo, Gardner, & Berntson, 1997; Fincham & Linfield, 1997).

Indeed, very little is known in general about the affective impact of one's ambivalent attitudes (Jonas et al., 2000). With reference to the ingroup as an attitude object, only the affective consequences of univalent appraisals have been focused on by previous research and these are found to evoke affective responses (cf. Smith, 1993). However, no prior work has been conducted on the potential affective effects of ingroup ambivalence. Therefore, the current study explored the issue of whether ingroup ambivalence impacts on group members' affect.

On the one hand, ambivalence toward social groups has been proposed to become salient primarily in intergroup situations (Katz, Wackenhut, & Hass, 1986). On the other hand, assuming that people

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strive for attitudinal consistency, they should positively evaluate attitude objects associated with only positive attributes and, conversely, negatively evaluate those associated with only negative attributes (cf. Brehm & Cohen, 1962; Heider, 1958). Based on this reasoning, Priester and Petty (1996, 2001) have suggested that attitudinal ambivalence (e.g. positive and negative evaluations simultaneously associated with a positively-evaluated attitude object) may be more psychologically salient to the individual than attitudinal univalence (i.e. non-conflicting evaluations). Accordingly, in the present study once our participants had assessed an ingroup in an intergroup context (after Katz et al., 1986), we predicted that the greater the participants' ambivalence towards the ingroup the more intense their experienced affect would be (Hypothesis 1).

However, on a range of measures ingroup identification has been shown to moderate individuals' reactions to situations where their own group's value is threatened (for a review, see Branscombe, Ellemers, Spears, & Doosje, 1999). Indeed, high(er) ingroup identifiers are more likely to be motivated to maintain a positive view of the ingroup (Brewer & Kramer, 1985; Turner, 1978). Accordingly, such group members can also be expected to be more sensitive to the potential value threats to their social identity represented by ambivalent attitudes toward the ingroup. This prediction should hold because high identifiers have been found, in general, to be more involved with the ingroup (e.g. Wann & Branscombe, 1993).

A recent study on intergroup ambivalence by Mucchi Faina, Costarelli, and Romoli (2002) is also relevant to the present research. Based on their findings, these authors have argued that ingroup ambivalence can serve the function of allowing group members to show the evaluative objectivity that is prescribed by principles of fairness in intergroup evaluation. However, social identity theory (Tajfel, 1981; Tajfel & Turner, 1979, 1986) predicts a positive relationship between one's own identification with the ingroup and maintenance of positive social identity. Based on this prior theoretical and empirical work, we expected that the affective impact of ingroup ambivalence would be moderated by the extent to which participants identify with the ingroup (Hypothesis 2). However, empirical findings relevant to this prediction are lacking in the extant literature. As a consequence, we decided that the direction of the hypothesized difference in the scores of the dependent measures should remain an empirical question.

METHOD

Participants and Design

One hundred and twenty (non-psychology majors) undergraduates from the University of Ferrara (66 women, 54 men; mean age = 20.45) voluntarily completed a questionnaire. They were randomly assigned to one of the two design cells resulting from the rating order of the target groups (ingroup first vs outgroup first).

Dependent Measures

Attitudes were expressed along a 6-point unipolar scale (0 = *not at all*, 5 = *extremely*) with no neutral point. Participants' attitudes towards the target groups were operationalized as responses to eight randomly-ordered items. Following Kaplan (1972), this measure was obtained by splitting each of four typically bipolar semantic differential scales that were taken from a study by MacDonald and Zanna (1998) into two unipolar items. Thus, one unipolar item assessed the endorsement of the positive pole of the bipolar scale (e.g. 'Italians: are not at all likeable/extremely likeable'), whereas the other unipolar item measured the endorsement of the negative pole of the bipolar scale (e.g. 'Italians: are not at all dislikeable/extremely dislikeable'). This operation resulted in eight unipolar items differing in valence. The positively-valenced traits were: *likeable*, *funny*, *attractive*, *admirable*. The negatively-valenced traits were: *dislikeable*, *sad making*, *repulsive*, *contemptible*. For positively-valenced items a low rating implied less favourability toward the target groups than a high rating; for negatively-valenced items a low rating implied less unfavourability toward the target groups than a high rating. In this way, separate ranking of positivity (e.g. 'admirable') and negativity (e.g. 'contemptible') simultaneously allowed participants' reports to indicate that they had both positive and negative attitudes to members of the target groups.

This methodological artifice allowed us to calculate one of the two measures of ambivalence that we used in this study. One regards ambivalence as a structural property of respondents' attitude and is measured by combining the positive and the negative evaluations of the target groups into one arithmetical formula, namely, *formula-based* ambivalence. The other measure of ambivalence we used in this work reflects participants' conscious acknowledgement that they hold a mixed evaluation (i.e. both positive and negative) of the target groups, namely, *experienced* ambivalence. These two types of ambivalence are typically only moderately related (cf. Priester & Petty, 1996; Thompson et al., 1995). Therefore, measurement of both types of ambivalence should be conducive to a more complete assessment of the impact of attitudinal ambivalence on psychological phenomena (cf. Conner & Sparks, 2002; Jonas et al., 2000). Experienced ambivalence taps the effects exerted by people's awareness of their own accessible attitudinal inconsistencies toward a given attitude object. However, formula-based indices may have the additional potential to 'generate aspects [of the attitude] that are not automatically salient when respondents answer items about their experienced ambivalence' (Jonas et al., 2000, p. 49).

Experienced ambivalence towards the target groups was assessed by two questions on 6-point scales (0 = *not at all*, 5 = *extremely*) with no neutral point. This measure was a reduced version of that developed by Priester and Petty (1996), tapping both the cognitive and affective components of experienced ambivalence toward a given attitude object ('Thinking about Italians/Foreigners, to what extent are your opinions toward them mixed?', and 'Thinking about Italians/Foreigners, to what extent do your feelings toward them conflict?', respectively). By averaging mean scores for each of these two items ($r = 0.87$) we calculated an unweighted mean score for experienced ingroup ambivalence.

Participants' ingroup identification was assessed on a 6-point scale (0 = *not at all*, 5 = *extremely*) with no neutral point, and measured by Haslam, Oakes, Reynolds, and Turner's single-item measure (1999)—a measure that a recent review of social identification measures reports as being highly correlated with other global measures of the same construct (cf. Haslam, 2001). This measure taps the perceived importance of ingroup membership ('How important is it to be Italian for you?').

Measures of positive and negative affect were derived from participants' ratings of their own positive and negative affect. These were obtained after evaluating the target groups on 6-point scales (0 = *does not apply at all*, 5 = *applies very much)* with no neutral point. Participants were asked to 'indicate the degree to which each of the following adjectives describes how you feel now'. Additionally, they were instructed not to think too much about their ratings and instead to give quick, gut-level responses.

Our choice of such a measure was deliberate. On the one hand, the items we employed to measure positive and negative affect were derived from Devine, Monteith, Zuwerink, and Elliot's results (1991, Study 1) of a factorial analysis conducted on a number of positive and negative affect items. However, to measure positive affect we chose to use just those specific items that could not be considered as measuring respondents' self-esteem-based positive affect (namely, *energetic*, *glad*, *content*). This decision was taken on the basis of Hogg and Abrams' conclusion (1988) that social identity theory's 'self-esteem hypothesis' (Tajfel & Turner, 1979) specifies an unclear relationship between self-esteem and intergroup behaviour. The negative affect measure we used comprised some of those negative affect items which in Devine et al.'s study (1991) loaded uniquely on the factor that they interpreted as reflecting negative feelings directed at the self (namely, *angry at myself*, *guilty*, *disappointed with myself)*.

Procedure

Participants completed a questionnaire allegedly designed to investigate European students' attitudes. It was then explained that participants should give their evaluations of both their own national group (i.e. Italians) and foreigners who, for various reasons, come to their own country ('e.g. students of the Italian language; immigrant workers; tourists, etc.'). Respondents were asked not to rate one specific member of the target groups they might personally know, but rather to give their impressions of the target groups' members in general.

Initially, participants were asked to indicate their age, gender and main subject. The first part of the questionnaire then asked participants to rate the target groups on a number of randomly-ordered items. The order in which the two groups were rated was counterbalanced. Participants were then asked to answer two questions about the extent to which their opinions and feelings about the target groups were mixed and conflicted, respectively. Subsequently, participants were asked to answer a question about their identification with the national ingroup. Finally, they were required to rate their affect based on how they felt after completing 'the prior task' (i.e. the evaluating measures). Before leaving, participants were fully debriefed and thanked.

RESULTS

Preliminary Analyses

Various composite indices were constructed. For each target group a four-item positive evaluation index (Cronbach's αs: ingroup $= 0.82$; outgroup $= 0.70$), and a four-item negative evaluation index (αs: ingroup $= 0.72$; outgroup $= 0.76$) were constructed.

Participants' ratings of the ingroup and the outgroup expressed on the positively- and the negatively-valenced items, although highly correlated (rs $= -0.43$ and -0.54, respectively), were not completely reciprocal. Therefore, the computation of formula-based ingroup ambivalence appeared methodologically justified. Accordingly, formula-based ingroup ambivalence scores were computed for each participant. Measures of experienced ambivalence are often regarded as the 'gold standard' against which to validate competing formula-based measures (cf. Thompson et al., 1995; but see also Jonas et al., 2000). Accordingly, to calculate formula-based ingroup ambivalence scores we chose to use the Gradual Threshold Model of ambivalence (Priester & Petty, 1996) because of its ability to predict experienced ambivalence better than all other mathematical models of ambivalence (for a discussion, see Priester & Petty, 1996). In this model, ambivalence is equal to $5Wp - S1/W$, where W and S are equal to the weaker and stronger attitude score, respectively, p is the slope relating the weaker attitude score to the degree of experienced ambivalence (0.48 in the present instance), and a constant of 1 is added to W and S. Consistent with previous evidence (for a review, see Jonas et al., 2000), the scores for formula-based and experienced ambivalence toward the ingroup correlated only moderately ($r = 0.39$, $p < 0.01$).

Finally, affect indices were constructed. We conducted a principal components factor analysis (with Varimax rotation) to check whether the six affect items on which participants rated their own affect could be clustered into two categories (i.e. positively- and negatively-valenced items). From this analysis a two-factorial solution emerged (total percentage variance explained = 82%) that accorded with Devine et al.'s (1991) composition of the 'positive' and 'negself' factors. Each affect item loaded on only one factor in the factor solution (our loading criterion was 0.40 or higher). This supported our initial selection of the specific items that were employed to construct separate positive and negative affect indices for each factor identified in the factor solution. Specifically, we did so by averaging participants' ratings for the items that loaded on each factor (αs: positive affect = 0.74; negative affect = 0.74). Positive and negative affect correlated slightly negatively ($r = -0.19$, $p < 0.05$). This supported our decision to measure them separately, consistent with the notion that positive and negative affect are independent dimensions (cf. Warr, Barter, & Brownbridge, 1983).

Preliminary analyses yielded no statistically significant main effects, or interactions with the variables of interest, for respondents' gender (male vs female), and group rating order (ingroup first vs outgroup first). Data were therefore collapsed across these variables in all of the following analyses.

Effects of Formula-based and Experienced Ingroup Ambivalence on Positive and Negative Affect as Moderated by Ingroup Identification

We expected that ingroup identification would moderate the impact of formula-based and experienced ambivalence toward the ingroup upon participants' reported positive and negative affect. Moderating effects of ingroup identification were assessed using moderated simultaneous hierarchical multiple regression analysis (cf. Aiken & West, 1991). The relationship we found between formula-based and experienced ambivalence toward the ingroup (see above) allowed us to examine the unique influences of each of the two measures of ingroup ambivalence while controlling for the other one. To this end, following Aiken and West's suggestion (1991), we first computed mean-centred scores for ingroup identification, formula-based and experienced ambivalence toward the ingroup. Then we entered these scores into step 1 of a hierarchical multiple regression model, the relevant two-way interaction terms into step 2, and the three-way interaction term into step 3. This model was tested first with positive affect, and then with negative affect, as the dependent variable.

Concerning positive and negative affect, these analyses yielded only main effects of experienced ingroup ambivalence, both ts > 2.25, both ps < 0.03. As predicted, reported affect was less positive ($\beta = -0.22$) and more negative ($\beta = 0.19$) the more ambivalent the participants were toward the ingroup. Of greatest interest, these main effects were qualified by the interaction of ingroup identification and experienced ingroup ambivalence, (positive affect: $t = -2.25$, $p < 0.05$; negative affect: $t = 2.06$, $p < 0.05$).

To decompose this interaction, we conducted and then compared the results of two separate sets of simple-regression analyses, one for low (ingroup) identifiers and one for high identifiers. We identified these two groups by splitting the sample on the median of the ingroup identification measure (= 3) in order to create low- ($M = 2.51$) a high- ($M = 4.33$) ingroup identification groups, $F(1, 119) = 97.72$, $p < 0.000$ (ingroup ambivalence- and outgroup ambivalence-ingroup identification correlations: both ps > 0.2, *ns*). This procedure allowed us to examine the influence of experienced ingroup ambivalence on positive and negative affect.

In the high-ingroup identification group, experienced ingroup ambivalence yielded a significant contribution to the regression equation on positive affect, $R^2 = 0.38$, $F(1, 119) = 8.19$, $p < 0.01$. As predicted, reported affect was less positive the more ambivalent the participants were toward the ingroup, $\beta = -0.51$. In contrast, as predicted, for the low-ingroup identification group ambivalence did not yield a significant contribution to the regression equation on positive affect, $R^2 < 0.1$, $F < 1$, *ns*.

Concerning negative affect, in the high-ingroup identification group the effect of experienced ingroup ambivalence yielded a significant contribution to the regression equation, $R^2 = 0.44$, $F(1, 119) = 8.55$, $p < 0.01$. As predicted, reported affect was more negative the more ambivalent participants were toward the ingroup on the measure of experienced ingroup ambivalence ($\beta = 0.63$). In contrast, in line with predictions, among the low identifiers the effect of experienced ingroup ambivalence did not make a significant contribution to the regression equation on negative affect, $t < 1$, *ns*, $R^2 < 0.10$, $F < 1$, *ns*.

It could, however, be argued that it is conceptually very likely that most people feel positive about the ingroup. Hence, ingroup ambivalence would be necessarily associated with univalent negativity toward the ingroup. However, in our sample we found ingroup negativity to be very highly associated only with formula-based ingroup ambivalence ($r = 0.95$, $p < 0.001$ for low identifiers; $r = 0.94$, $p < 0.001$ for high identifiers), but not with experienced ingroup ambivalence ($r = 0.06$, *ns* for low identifiers; $r = 0.15$, $p > 0.25$, *ns* for high identifiers). In other words, only this latter index of ingroup ambivalence was able to predict participants' affect (see above).

Thus, on the one hand, we can rule out univalent ingroup negativity effects as an alternative explanation for the reported impact of ingroup ambivalence on participants' positive and negative affect. On the other hand, however, the almost perfect correlation we found between ingroup negativity and formula-based ingroup ambivalence would seem to point to the fragility of the effects of the latter construct. Indeed, this provides indirect support for a line of reasoning suggesting that because of the various extrapersonal antecedents associated with experienced ambivalence (for a discussion, see Priester & Petty, 2001), 'the use of a more global construct that directly assesses the feelings of evaluative tension may be more effective in predicting some ambivalence-related attitude phenomena' (p. 32).

Ancillary Analyses

Previous research has revealed the negative affective consequences of being ambivalent toward the outgroup (e.g. Katz et al., 1986). Consistently, an alternative approach might contend that the reported affective consequences of ingroup ambivalence were in fact a more global property of ambivalence toward social groups in general. To test the empirical tenability of this alternative explanation of our results, we conducted parallel analyses for *outgroup ambivalence*. To this end, we calculated formula-based outgroup ambivalence and entered it, together with experienced outgroup ambivalence and ingroup identification into a moderated simultaneous hierarchical multiple regression analysis. This allowed us to examine the unique influences of each of the two measures of outgroup ambivalence while controlling for the other one. Again following Aiken and West's suggestion (1991), the outgroup judgements were analysed in the same way as the ingroup judgements (see above).

Both of these analyses yielded no statistically reliable main or interaction effects of outgroup ambivalence, all ts < 2, all *ns*. Therefore, these results do not support the alternative hypothesis that the affective consequences of ingroup ambivalence were in fact a more global property of ambivalence toward social groups in general.

DISCUSSION

No prior work has been conducted on the potential affective effects of ingroup ambivalence. Therefore, the current study explored the issue of whether ingroup ambivalence impacts on group members' affect. Prior work suggests that ambivalent attitudes are more psychologically salient to the individual, relative to univalent ones (cf. Priester & Petty, 1996, 2001). Accordingly, we expected that the greater the participants' ingroup ambivalence the more intense their experienced affect would be. However, consistent with the predictions of social identity theory, research has shown that high identifiers are more likely to be involved with the ingroup than low identifiers. Based on this, we expected to observe effects of ingroup ambivalence on affect for high but not low ingroup identifiers.

Across two independent variables, our results involving two distinct measures of ambivalence toward the ingroup revealed convergent support for the hypothesized pattern. Clearly one important question in understanding our results is *why* in general a higher rather than a lower ambivalent attitude toward the ingroup should evoke greater psychological discomfort among high ingroup identifiers. One possibility is that the affective impact of ingroup ambivalence may be rooted in the fact that the formation of ambivalent attitudes is more strongly influenced by *negative* information than it is by positive information about the attitude object (Cacioppo & Berntson, 1994). Moreover, attitude research has demonstrated that, being more diagnostic (Leyens & Yzerbyt, 1992), negative information evokes stronger affective responses (Skowronski & Carlston, 1989) than positive information. Because the self is typically evaluated positively (e.g. Baumeister, 1998), self-categorization as a member of a certain group should imply that, as a default, this group will be evaluated positively (cf. Gaertner, Dovidio, Anastasio, Bachman, & Rust, 1993). When this is not the case, the high negativity that ambivalence embodies about the attitude object should reflect onto the affect experienced by individuals who are highly ambivalent toward their own group. This should occur because ambivalent attitudes are more psychologically salient to the individual than univalent ones (cf. Priester & Petty, 1996, 2001). With reference to this issue, however, the current study provided evidence that helps rule out ingroup univalent negativity effects as an explanation of the observed impact of ingroup ambivalence on participants' affect.

Indeed, a different conceptual perspective regarding the reasons why a higher rather than a lower ambivalent attitude toward the ingroup should be associated with greater discomfort among high ingroup identifiers may be advanced. Specifically, this view concerns behavioural *standards*. People's actions or perceptions that are not in line with their relevant standards may pose evaluative challenges to the overall integrity of self (cf. Steele, 1988). Higgins' self-discrepancy theory (1987), for example, predicts that general psychological discomfort should result from one's transgressions of normative standards for behaviour that 'significant others' (e.g. important referents or social norms) believe one should attain. In particular, this intragroup process-related view can account for our results in which we found ingroup ambivalence to impact on the affect of high but not low ingroup identifiers. Indeed, in those situations where one's social identity is salient, compliance with social norms is expected to be a linear function of group members' ingroup identification (Jetten, Spears, & Manstead, 1996).

To conclude, consistent with recent theoretical suggestions (e.g. Ho & Driscoll, 1998), by combining the logic of two distinct literatures, the advances of this exploratory study may contribute to reconcile intraindividual (e.g. Monteith, 1996) and socially-based perspectives accounting for the affective processes that are set in motion by intergroup evaluation. Clearly, however, the present study raises a number of theoretical and practical issues that need to be explored in future research. In particular, there would appear to be scope for exploring more broadly what the consequences of ingroup ambivalence are for high identifiers—including what forms of significant social action it leads to and how they attempt to deal with it.

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